All in all, the BJP's digital persona is like a giant, all-consuming, self-learning machine supremely well-adjusted to the exigencies of the present moment. If the medium is the message, they've got it down pat.

CONGRESS: THE HYBRID MODEL

Less endowed with resources by comparison, a digital-only campaign may actually serve the cause of fiscal prudence for the Grand Old Party! The BJP being divested of its *brahmastra* is a boon of sorts too. As for its own digital plans, launched under the optimistic motto 'Go Virtual For Victory', they seem to be a judicious cross between the old and the new—literally, old-style letters set afloat on the sea in new, electronic bottles.

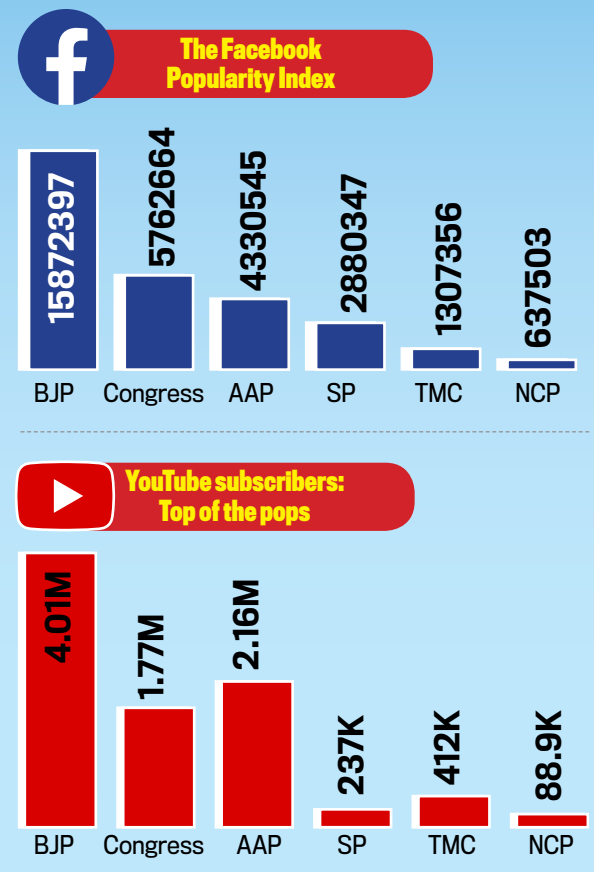
A set of 'Green Rooms' will be at the heart of the operation: one will be set up at the AICC headquarters, one in each state HQ, one at 10 Janpath. These will broadcast 'digital rallies' of senior leaders, going live through a selected list of social media handles—500 on Facebook, 300-400 on Twitter, 400-500 on Instagram. EC guidelines permitting, the party will also put up LED screens and digital vans at various locations across the poll-bound states. Once the live addresses are done, snippets of the rallies, including visuals of the people watching, will be distributed through WhatsApp and Telegram groups. "Our goal is to ensure at least 5-10 lakh people watch these digital rallies in UP and Punjab, and 2-3 lakh in Goa, Uttarakhand and Manipur," says Rohan Gupta, Congress digital media in-charge.

The party also intends to spread word about the Congress manifestos in a series of online drives—breaking down its salient points in easily digestibe snippets. These will be distributed through social media and messenger apps, deploying micro-targeting to reach specific groups defined by age, gender, class and region. "It's important to customise. What matters to the youth may not appeal to the elderly. What could be a big issue in Purvanchal may have no resonance in western UP," says Gupta. Local culture, language, music...these are seen as key.

Around 50 social media warriors are earmarked for each assembly segment. Another 50 will work exclusively for each candidate. There will be WhatsApp and Telegram groups for each constituency. The party is also considering coming up with apps. "The entire thing will be organically driven by Congress workers. Some vendors will offer us technical assistance, but the narrative and packaging will be ours," asserts Gupta. As in-charges of the social media blitz, the party has appointed Ruchira Chaturvedi for UP, Hasiba Amin for Goa, Saral Patel for Uttarakhand, Gaurav Pandhi for Punjab and Pranav Vachharjani for Manipur. The control room in Delhi will manage all technical aspects, including digital rallies, townhalls, manifesto launches and press conferences.

In Punjab, PCC chief Navjot Singh Sidhu set things rolling on January 9 with a virtual press conference. Claiming

LIKE, SUBSCRIBE, SHARE: POLITICS IN DEMAT FORM



that the Punjab Congress has maximum engagements and outreach in the digital space in his state, Sidhu said: "We are ready... our social media war room already has over 10,000 WhatsApp groups and we're reaching people at the booth level via Facebook and WhatsApp." The party is using the hashtag #LokadiSarkar to emphasise CM Charanjit Singh Channi's 'people's man' image in contrast to his predecessor Capt Amarinder Singh's royal hauteur.

In UP, Priyanka Gandhi has been very active on social media platforms. She has done several FB Live sessions, answering audience questions. The model of the ongoing Shakti Samvads, a virtual outreach to women, will be replicated in e-discussions with groups of farmers, youth, Asha workers and artisans. These too will be pushed through Twitter, WhatsApp, Telegram and Signal. In Uttarakhand, the party will instal over 200 projector screens to beam virtual rallies, townhalls, FB Lives and pressers. The slogan '*3-tigada kam-bigada* (a dig at the BJP's three CMs)' has already gone viral. In Goa, a blitz of graphics and illustrations paints the ruling BJP as a 'destroyer of the environment', and the TMC and AAP as 'B-teams'.

In Manipur, the virtual battle is already heating up and the smell of digital cordite permeates the air. The Congress has